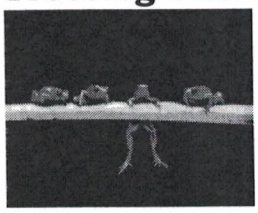
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FRAGMENTS OF A LIFE

By Brian Weilert

Author's note: It is intended to have each section of the story separated by a page turn in prose.

TEASER

Where others may *doodle* when bored, I strived for something much greater. In place of the spin-wheels, checker patterns, loop-de-loops of shapeless scrawls and scribbles, I composed words; a short story to be exact; restrained only by the boundaries of the objects upon which I wrote. I wrote whenever I could, on anything I could. Often times these limited spaces reduced my scholarly pursuits to short snippets, each written on their own unique pallet. Together they sequenced a sad life documented on the surfaces of the world.

END TEASER

On the back of a fortune cookie insert
He was never happier than at this moment with this woman.

A Post-It at work
He hated his job. Short of feeding his genitalia to a convention of ravenous Guinea pigs, he thought coming to work was a very close second.

Margin of the *Times*
When she moved in, things changed he changed she changed things just….changed.

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The March 29th square on a desk-calendar
The boy's father always said, *"When you put your hand in a bucket of water and pull it out; the hole that is left is how much people will miss you when you're gone."* A bit of a cynic, his dad. He had hoped it wasn't true but as he emptied out his center drawer and

loaded his things into a box: Pens and pencils, a stapler, Post-its, a tape dispenser, and his favorite Polaroid of his girl and him taken by a man in front of a Chinese restaurant, he saw people avoiding eye contact, busying themselves with the daily grind....and he knew what his father had said was true.

Empty microwave popcorn bag
She started spending more and more time sitting in front of the computer. From the glow of the monitor he watched as she smiled, before flicking-clicking a rapid typed response to an unknown, unseen competitor.

The Napkin at Starbucks ***(all space used)***
There she sits in the corner, piston stiff, greasy black hair, a vertical blind over thick-rimmed bifocals that ought not be worn by a girl in her early twenties. She is reading a library issued paper back with the cover folded hiding the truth that she has a passion for passion. Several dog-eared pages reveal the fact that many teenage boys have checked it out. She feels his stare and glances up, catching him in the act. She smiles and he fantasize about all the things she is thinking about him after reading such a book as that. She rises and waves. He waves and his heart picks up its pace. She moves toward him. His hands are actually sweating; his mind is racing for a clever opening, his mouth void of moisture. She nears, 10 feet. It's so silly, he has a girl friend, 7 feet, and the girl really isn't even that attractive, 5 feet, but still- to be desired, 2 feet, and that book, she passes by. He turns to see her hug a man with ratty jeans and an AC/DC tank top. He is a fool in his own world.

A hotel receipt from inside his girlfriend's purse
The man had been forgetting things lately, irritating his woman. So, he wrote them down: two heads of lettuce, a bag of radishes, a bottle of wine *(the sweet kind),* and a National Enquirer. He looked at the list and felt as if he were a child. He became angry at her and tore up the list. It's not like she was ever home to cook anyway.

The Bathroom stall at the airport
She left him for another man, a guy she met on the internet. He was proud of how he kept his pride, stoic as she tried to push his familiar buttons. He stood silent and unmoved as she packed her bags. Self controlled as she smashed the picture, the one taken by a man in front of the restaurant. Impassive and unfeeling as she spat in his face. All this, until he cried, a blithering idiot, begging her to stay as he drove her to the airport.

Coaster at a bar
Stale peanuts are like love....even when they've gone bad you can't stop eating.

A Cinder block at county lock-up
Drunk, he staggered to a phone pole for balance before leaning to expel the contents of his stomach. Harsh liquor and the pain of loss caused the system to rebel against its master. Wiping his eyes, he looked up to see the blurred enticing flash of a neon Bud sign across the street. It was the last thing he remembered.

Edge of an Eviction notice
Dominoes are funny things, you stand one alone, knock it over and it isn't very exciting; almost a non-event. You can withstand the impact on the universe by either ignoring the wooden tile or quite effortlessly standing it up again. But take this very same domino and invite two thousand of his closest friends, stand them in single file as though awaiting opening night tickets for a Harry Potter movie and when one falls, it is mesmerizing, and cataclysmic all in one. One hits and then another and you can't stop it. Fumbling fingers only exacerbate the problem. The only way to end the siege is to move ahead of the tumble and knock one in the opposite direction.

Bottom of a tennis shoe
The wind bites at the ragged man's ears, pink flesh that would shatter if flicked by a finger. He rummages through his shopping cart in an effort to find something, anything to cover his head. Hunger gives way to uncontrolled shivers. He pushes aside a Chevy hubcap and a bag of aluminum cans to reveal a tattered picture of two once happy lovers in front of a Chinese restaurant. The tears freeze halfway down his unshaven cheek.

Inside a large box tucked next to an alley dumpster
The man kept knocking at doors, begging someone to let him in, but no one would. He was clearly in distress as they peered at him through peep-holes and behind cracks with chains. Each time as he opened his mouth to speak the people would disappear. Finally, only half way down the street, at a house much like the others he had already visited, he just curled up on the stoop and died. It was just easier than going on; the only way to stop the falling of the dominoes.

Back of a Polaroid clutched in a dead man's hand
I miss her.

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